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Research Article

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Psychological Capital Predictors in Special Education Teachers: Compassion and Rumination

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Abstract

The aim of this study is to analyze the relationship between psychological capital, compassion, and rumination levels among special education teachers and the effect of these variables on psychological capital. Based on this objective, 189 special education teachers working in the field of special education in the province of Konya were included in the study. The research design was developed as a correlational survey model. The Personal Information Form, Positive Psychological Capital Scale, Rumination Responses Scale, and Compassion Scale were used in order to collect data for the study. The scales were administered to the participants via Google Forms, and data analysis was performed using the SPSS 27 software package. Pearson correlation analysis was utilized in order to determine the relationships between variables; linear regression analysis was used to determine the effect of compassion and rumination on psychological capital. The findings indicate that compassion levels have a positive significant relationship with positive psychological capital, while rumination has a negative significant relationship. Regression analysis revealed that positive psychological capital is significantly predicted by the variables of compassion and rumination. In the epilogue of the study, the findings obtained from the research are discussed in the light of the literature and recommendations are presented.

Key Words

Compassion • Psychological capital • Rumination • Special education

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Introduction

Issues such as student-teacher and school-family conflicts during the education and teaching process, disciplinary problems related to students, excessively large class sizes and insufficient physical standards, social criticism and lack of community support, and social and political pressures on educational institutions are cited as reasons why the teaching profession experiences more intense stress compared to other service sectors ([Şahin & Şahin, 2012](#)). Teaching, which is considered a highly stressful profession, can become even more stressful when it comes to individuals with special educational needs, due to a combination of factors such as the characteristics of these children, the intensity of direct contact, difficulties in control, and the challenges of the teaching process ([Girgin & Baysal, 2005](#)). The literature shows that special education teachers can experience problems such as irrational thoughts, negative automatic thoughts, emotional instability issues, and deterioration in healthy coping skills with stress, stemming from many different variables ([Gönüldaş & Gümüşkaya, 2022](#)). In contrast to these negative psychological processes related to the education and teaching process, the concept of psychological capital is positively associated with variables such as job satisfaction, motivation, problem-solving skills, and professional success. It is observed that teachers' ability to cope healthily with the problems they encounter, to have positive expectations for the future, and their commitment to their profession are closely related to positive psychological capital ([Tösten & Özgan, 2014](#); [Deniz & Kılıç, 2025](#)).

The emergence of positive psychology as we know it today dates back to Seligman's 1998 speech at the American Psychological Association. However, the literature actually shows that positive psychology has been present in our lives for much longer, albeit unnoticed as a comprehensive body of knowledge. The main points of positive psychology, which overlap with many aspects of humanistic psychology and emphasize functional, healthy individuals and self-actualization, are to reinforce, elevate, and celebrate what we know about the things that make life worth living, and to carefully identify the areas where we need to do more ([Linley et al., 2006](#)). The concept of psychological capital, developed within the positive psychology approach, is described as one of the important determinants of individuals' behavioral motivations in work environments and as the psychological developmental state of individuals ([Luthans et al., 2004](#)). Positive psychological capital, a concept centered on individuals' innate strengths and their expression through positive behavioral patterns, supports the emergence and further development of individuals' positive and constructive aspects, rather than their negative aspects, contrary to traditional attitudes ([Deviren, 2025](#)). Positive psychological capital essentially focuses on individuals' strengths. While developing this resource is important for individuals specifically, in a general context, it significantly increases the efficiency and effectiveness of professional organization ([İnce & Yeşiltaş, 2025](#)). Psychological capital, defined as the ability to stand firm in the face of challenges, the belief that one will succeed in the present and future, and the power to discover and manage oneself, consists of four elements: self-efficacy belief, perseverance in achieving goals, and the ability to redirect paths to the goal when necessary to achieve success (hope), a tendency to have positive expectations (optimism), and resilience ([Luthans et al., 2007](#)).

Self-efficacy: Representing an individual's belief in their own abilities, self-efficacy is their judgment of how well they can perform the actions necessary to cope with situations they may encounter in the future. This judgment influences mechanisms such as initiating behavior, determining how much effort to exert, and sustaining that effort ([Stajkovic & Luthans, 1998](#)).

Hope: Hope, which encompasses the willpower and motivational energy necessary to move toward a goal, implies not only setting goals but also finding alternative ways to achieve them. It fosters the desire to succeed, finding the paths to success, clarifying them, and following them (Snyder, 2000).

Optimism: Positive psychology defines optimism as an individual's way of attributing causes to positive or negative events. According to Seligman (1998), optimistic individuals attribute positive events to internal and permanent causes, while attributing negative events to external and temporary causes (Luthans et al., 2007). Psychological capital, on the other hand, approaches optimism as the concept of “realistic optimism” and defines it as an individual's capacity to form positive expectations while being aware of their own limitations. Realistic optimism involves the individual assessing what they can or cannot achieve in certain situations and therefore contributes to the individual's effectiveness and hope (Luthans, 2002).

Resilience: One of the fundamental concepts of positive psychology, resilience is characterized by having positive coping strategies in the face of risks and challenges and a high capacity for adaptation. It is defined as a positive psychological capacity to recover, strengthen, and bounce back in the face of challenges, uncertainties, conflicts, and failures, as well as positive changes, progress, and increased responsibilities (Luthans, 2002).

Positive psychology encompasses not only individuals' personal strengths but also the constructive and empathetic relationships they build with others (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000). At this point, compassion involves being affected by the suffering of others, opening one's self-awareness to the suffering of others and not avoiding it, thus encompassing feelings of compassion towards others and the desire to alleviate their suffering. Compassion, which offers nonjudgmental understanding to those who fail or make mistakes, implies viewing actions and behaviors in the context of shared human fallibility (Neff, 2003). Compassion is an emotion that motivates a person to help or favor themselves and others, encompassing situations such as helping, being fair, and not resorting to violence. Teachers' sense of compassion stands out as a factor that significantly influences their approach to students and the learning experience. Compassion increases understanding, confidence, and supportive attitudes towards students. It is an important part of the education process for teachers working with individuals with special needs to feel empathy and to plan their education with motivation regarding how they should perceive the thoughts, behaviors, and feelings of these students (Nuri & Varol, 2021). It is believed that teachers with a high level of compassion, which is a fundamental requirement in educational settings, will contribute to learning levels by setting an example for their students and creating a positive educational environment (Brundiers & Wiek, 2017).

From a positive psychology perspective, compassion has been found to increase self-awareness and facilitate emotional regulation (Neff & Germer, 2018). However, emotional regulation processes may not always be functional. When an individual does not accept and understand the negative experiences they have had, but instead thinks about them repeatedly, this process takes the form of ruminative thinking (Nolen-Hoeksema, 1991). The word rumination, which originates from Latin, is described as “mental rumination,” reflecting situations such as thoughts constantly repeating in the mind and the mind becoming constantly exhausted in this way (Can & Aydın, 2022). This cognitive process, while not primarily aimed at problem-solving, directs the individual's attention and energy toward negative content, thereby perpetuating emotional distress (Smith & Alloy, 2009). Rumination, which has two dimensions—obsessive thinking and deep thinking—is not limited to

past experiences but can also persist in completed, unfinished, or completely different situations in the present and future (Er & Ulu, 2024).

Teaching is a prototypical profession in which employees continue to use their homes as part of their workplace. According to OECD (2014) data, it is observed that they complete many work-related tasks at home, such as preparing lessons, grading exams, and planning school activities. Teachers strive to meet many different demands, primarily expectations from parents, while continuing to fulfill their educational mission. Coping with these multiple demands can create stressful situations and, when it results in not having enough time for education and teaching, it can also create extra work pressure. At this point, as the findings of meta-analysis research also reveal, for a functional teaching process, it is necessary for the teacher to be psychologically healthy (Türktorun et al., 2020).

Special education teachers encounter challenging student behaviors at a higher rate and experience situations that require a high level of patience and empathy. Therefore, understanding their psychological capital levels and strengthening them through future studies is considered critical for both teacher well-being and the education provided to individuals with special needs. While there are numerous studies on special education teachers related to burnout, it is observed that compassion and psychological capital, which are concepts from positive psychology, have been studied to a very limited extent. This research is expected to contribute to this gap in the literature. Based on this, the aim of this study is to examine the relationship between psychological capital, compassion, and rumination levels among special education teachers and the effect of these variables on psychological capital.

Method

Research Design

The purpose of this study is to examine the relationship between psychological capital, compassion, and rumination in special education teachers and to determine the effect of these variables on psychological capital. The study was conducted using a correlational survey model. Karasar (2005) defines the correlational survey model as a research model used to examine whether two or more variables change together and, if so, to investigate the extent of this change.

Study Group

The study group consists of special education teachers working in special education centers, guidance and research centers, and special education subclasses in the province of Konya. A priori power analysis conducted using GPower 3.1 indicated that a minimum sample size of 68 participants was required for the regression analysis ($f^2 = 0.15$, $\alpha = .05$, power = .80, two predictors). The final sample consisted of 189 participants, including 123 women and 66 men, selected at random, exceeding the required number and demonstrating sufficient statistical power.

Research Instruments and Processes

Before data collection, ethical approval was obtained from the Necmettin Erbakan University Social and Human Sciences Research Ethics Committee (Decision No: 2025/513, Date: May 30, 2025). Following ethical approval, permission was obtained from the relevant institutions where the special education teachers were

employed. Data collection was carried out using an online survey method. The data collection tools were transferred to Google Forms and distributed to special education teachers working in special education centers, guidance and research centers, and special education classrooms in Konya province. Participation in the study was voluntary, and participants were informed about the purpose of the research and confidentiality principles before completing the questionnaires. The data were collected within a specified time period, and only fully completed forms were included in the analysis.

The Scale of Positive Psychological Capital

Developed by Tösten and Özgan (2014), the scale aims to measure teachers' positive psychological capital competencies. The scale, consisting of 26 items and using a 5-point Likert scale, comprises 6 sub-dimensions: self-efficacy, optimism, trust, extraversion, psychological resilience, and hope. In the validity and reliability study, the scale's Cronbach Alpha value was found to be .92, proving it to be a valid and reliable scale (Tösten & Özgan, 2014). There are no reverse-scored items in the scale, and analysis is performed using the total score. In this study, the scale's Cronbach Alpha value was determined to be .93, and analyses were performed based on the total score.

Rumination Responses Scale

The scale, adapted into Turkish by Erdur-Baker and Bugay (2012), was developed by Nolen-Hoaksema and Marrow (1991) to measure individuals' ruminative coping styles. The scale, which showed high fit indices for both the long and short forms in confirmatory factor analyses, consists of 10 items on a 4-point Likert scale in its short form. The total score of the scale can also be calculated and consists of two subscales: obsessive thinking and deep thinking. The scale has a Cronbach's alpha value of .85. For this study, the internal consistency value was also found to be .85, and the analyses were performed based on the total score.

Compassion Scale

Developed by Pommier (2010) and adapted into Turkish by Akdeniz and Deniz (2016), the Compassion Scale is a 5-point Likert-type scale consisting of 24 items. The scale has six subscales: affection, indifference, awareness of sharing, detachment, conscious awareness, and relationship termination. Indifference, detachment, and relationship termination subscales are reversed to obtain the total score. In the compassion scale, as the total score increases, the level of compassion also increases. In the validity and reliability study conducted by Akdeniz and Deniz (2016), the Cronbach Alpha value of the scale was found to be .85. In this study, the Cronbach Alpha value was measured as .86, and the analyses were performed based on the total score.

Personal Information Form

A personal information form developed by researchers was administered to determine the socio-demographic data of individuals participating in the study. The form included information such as age, gender, type of institution employed, length of service in the field of special education, and marital status.

Data Analysis

In the analysis of the data, percentage and frequency analyses were first performed to determine the descriptive data of the individuals included in the study. Cronbach Alpha analysis was conducted to calculate the internal consistency of the scales, and normality analyses were performed using skewness and kurtosis values.

Pearson Correlation Analysis was performed to determine the relationship between variables, and linear regression analysis was performed to determine the effect of independent variables on the dependent variable. The SPSS 27 software package was used for data analysis.

Results

Descriptive Findings

When examining the mean total scale scores of the study group in Table 1, it is seen that the psychological capital scores are 130 ± 11.66 , the compassion scores are 120 ± 10.06 , and the rumination scores are 10 ± 5.07 . Similarly, when examining the internal consistency values related to scale scores, Cronbach Alpha values of .93 for positive psychological capital, .86 for compassion, and .85 for rumination were obtained. Findings regarding skewness and kurtosis values were -.26 to -.58 for psychological capital, -.61 to .34 for compassion, and .64 to 1.34 for rumination. Upon examining the data, it was observed that the validity and reliability levels of the measurement tools used were good, and the data showed a normal distribution (George & Mallery, 2003; Hair et al., 2010; Tabachnick & Fidell, 2013).

Table 1

Descriptive findings on psychological capital, compassion, and rumination (n=189)

Variables	α	M	SD	Skewness	Kurtosis
Psychological Capital	.93	130.00	11.66	-.26	-.58
Compassion	.86	120.00	10.06	-.61	.34
Rumination	.85	10.00	5.07	.64	1.34

Examination of the Relationship Between Variables

The results of the Pearson correlation analysis conducted to determine the relationship between special education teachers' positive psychological capital, compassion, and rumination levels are presented in Table 2. Upon examining the findings, a positive relationship was observed between psychological capital and compassion ($r=.49$, $p<.01$), and a negative relationship was observed between psychological capital and rumination ($r=-.21$, $p<.01$).

Table 2

The relationship between psychological capital, compassion, and rumination

	1	2	3
1. Psychological Capital	-		
2. Compassion	.49**	-	
3. Rumination	-.21**	.025	-

** $p<.01$

The Effect of Predictor Variables on Psychological Capital

Table 3 shows that the multiple regression analysis conducted to determine the effect of compassion level and ruminative thinking level on positive psychological capital among special education teachers is significant ($p<.01$). The explanatory power of the model was calculated as $R^2=.29$, indicating that 29% of the variance in psychological capital scores was explained by the variables of compassion and rumination ($R=.54$, $p<.01$). Table 3 shows that compassion ($\beta=.50$, $t=8.11$) and rumination ($\beta=-.23$, $t=-3.76$) significantly explain positive psychological capital.

Table 3

The effect of compassion and rumination scores on psychological capital

Predictor Variable	B	Sh	t	β	p
Constant	62.33	7.57	8.03		<.001
Compassion	.58	.07	8.11	.50	<.001
Rumination	-.53	.14	-3.76	-.23	<.001
R= .54	R ² = .29				
F= 39.09	p<.01				

Discussion, Conclusion, and Suggestions

The research results show that the level of compassion in special education teachers is positively related to positive psychological capital, while rumination is negatively related. The national literature reveals that there are very few studies on the concepts of compassion, rumination, and psychological capital in special education teachers. At this point, studies on these concepts in other professions were also utilized. The relevant literature appears to present findings that are parallel to the findings of this study.

A study by Wang and colleagues (2024) found that psychological capital in the workplace may serve as a mechanism that can reduce ruminative processes. A study by Chen and colleagues (2023) also revealed a significant negative relationship between rumination and psychological capital, showing that rumination plays a mediating role in the depressive symptoms of negative life events, while psychological capital functions as a variable that buffers this negative effect. This finding contradicts the study by Omar and colleagues (2024). The study shows that psychological capital and job satisfaction have a positive effect on performance, but rumination, despite being a negative predictor, has no moderating effect. However, the literature also presents different evidence regarding the relationship between rumination and psychological capital. Specifically, some intervention studies have found that increasing psychological capital does not lead to a significant decrease in rumination levels (Mansourieh, 2021). Another study by Xu and colleagues (2022), which argues that rumination does not always produce negative outcomes but can produce positive outcomes in some cases, reveals a significant relationship between rumination and post-traumatic growth and creativity, showing that the effects of rumination vary depending on the context.

When studies on compassion and psychological capital in the literature are examined, results supporting the findings of this research are obtained. In a study conducted by Hu and colleagues (2022), a positive and significant relationship was found between compassion and psychological capital, and it was observed that compassion strengthens psychological capital. Another study on the positive psychological capital of individuals working in professions with excessive workloads in South Korea also found that the negative relationship between excessive workload and emotional commitment can be reduced by the employee's level of compassion (Ko et al., 2022). Again, in a study by Ko and Choi (2019) investigating the extent to which compassion affects employee job performance, it was found that compassion creates a positive and significant change in job performance and that positive psychological capital mediates this relationship. These findings provide strong support for interpreting the effect of compassion on psychological capital in this study, which was conducted on a sample of special education teachers. A study conducted by Maillet and Read (2024) examined the effect of nurses' psychological capital on compassion fatigue and compassion satisfaction. The research reveals that psychological capital has a meaningful relationship with these two variables, but that the effects differ in terms

of level among different groups of nurses. This finding indicates that the level of interaction and relationship between compassion and psychological capital may vary depending on the context and professional conditions. There are studies in the literature that reveal that psychological capital and compassion influence each other reciprocally. A study conducted with nurses in our country emphasizes that psychological capital positively predicts compassion, and therefore, it is necessary to pay attention to the levels of compassion and psychological capital among employees and to develop strategies that can support them (Malak et al., 2025). At this point, it is thought that the effect of compassion on psychological capital in occupational groups that require a high level of emotional labor, such as special education teachers, should be addressed in many different contexts and sources. Findings showing that compassion strengthens the social support context as well as individual psychological resources highlight the importance of compassion-focused interventions and strategies to reduce the negative effects of rumination.

This study examined the effect of compassion and rumination levels on psychological capital among special education teachers. The results revealed that compassion is positively related to positive psychological capital and negatively related to rumination among special education teachers. Furthermore, 29% of the variance in psychological capital can be explained by compassion and rumination. The research data is limited to special education teachers working in special education institutions in the province of Konya. Based on this, the following recommendations can be made for researchers and practitioners: Future research could be conducted with larger sample groups or with special education teachers in different cities. This study, which was conducted only with special education teachers, could be replicated with teachers from different disciplines in future studies. This study examined the relationship between special education teachers' positive psychological capital and rumination and compassion. Similar studies could investigate the effect of different variables. Due to the cross-sectional nature of the study, which limits the ability to draw causal conclusions, it is recommended that similar studies be conducted using longitudinal designs. Awareness-based programs related to compassion levels can be implemented for special education teachers. Such programs have the potential to increase psychological capital. Mindfulness-based interventions may be recommended to reduce ruminative thinking tendencies, which are frequently observed in teachers.

Ethic

The research received ethical committee approval from the Necmettin Erbakan University Social and Human Sciences Research Ethics Committee on May 30, 2025, under decision number 2025/513.

Author Contributions

The authors contributed equally to the study.

Conflict of Interest

The authors declare that there is no conflict of interest regarding this study.

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